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Professor Kwon

Research 035

26 March 2026

Qualitative Research

Intro: Music streaming has become an essential part of Millennials' daily routine, whether they are in the car driving to work, with their kids, going to the gym, or using it as a way to bring people together. Over the past decade, platforms like Spotify have come to dominate the music streaming industry. As competition among different streaming services continues to grow, understanding what influences users to choose and remain loyal to a specific platform is increasingly important. Our qualitative research assignment explores why Millennials have decided to either recently join Spotify or remain loyal users.

Research Objectives: The objective of this study is to understand how Millennials evaluate and choose between music streaming platforms, with a focus on pricing, perceived value, and platform features that influence preference for Spotify.

Research Question: How do pricing and perceived value influence Millennials' decisions to choose or remain loyal to Spotify compared to other music streaming platforms?

Rationale for choosing interviews, focus groups, and specifics: This study used a qualitative research approach through a series of 16 in-depth interviews to better understand Millennials' perceptions of Spotify, especially regarding pricing and perceived value. We decided in-depth interviews were the best form of qualitative research for us because they allowed us to get a deeper look into participants' attitudes, behaviors, and decision-making processes, providing more detailed insights than surveys or other quantitative methods. In addition, since we were covering more sensitive topics like pricing and affordability, we wanted to make sure participants felt comfortable opening up to the interviewers. This approach also allowed us to better understand how people compare different music streaming platforms, as well as what influences their loyalty or willingness to switch. The interviews were conducted between March 12 and March 22, 2026, via phone call, and each lasted about 15–25 minutes. Participants

were asked open-ended questions about their relationship with music, how they view Spotify's pricing and value, and how it compares to other platforms. This structure kept the interviews consistent while still allowing participants to share their personal experiences and perspectives on the platform.

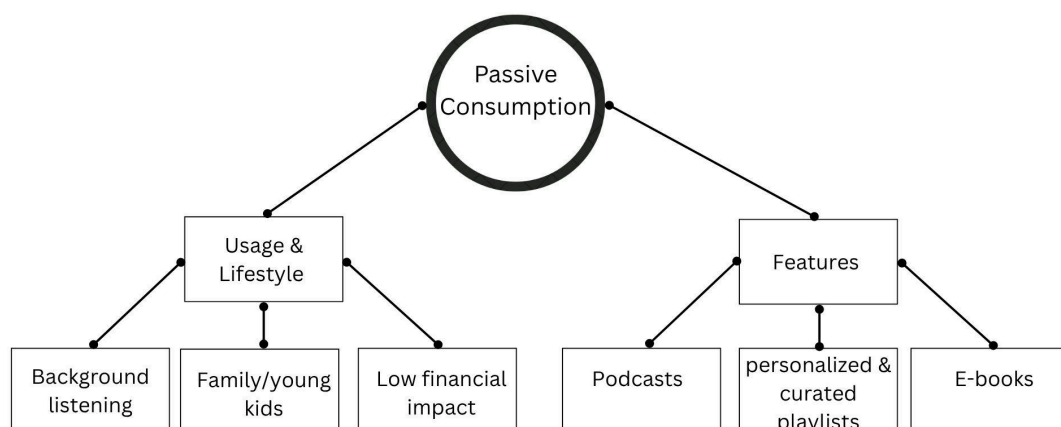
Description of participants: A total of 20 individuals were initially approached to participate in the study, all of whom were current Spotify users. Of those asked, 16 agreed to participate in the interviews. All participants were Millennials between the ages of 30 and 45 years old, including young professionals and working adults from diverse places like Austin, Houston, Louisiana, Washington, New York, and Colorado. This group was specifically selected because they represent a core demographic of Spotify users who are highly engaged with music streaming platforms. Their financial awareness and familiarity with Spotify allowed them to provide meaningful insights into pricing, perceived value, platform comparisons, and loyalty, all of which were central to the objectives of this study.

Key Findings and Insights: From the qualitative research we have conducted, it is evident that millennials' loyalty to Spotify is mainly because of the perceived value, price sensitivity, and comparison to competitors. People feel Spotify is worth what they pay for because of personalized playlists, strong algorithm-centered recommendations, convenience, and accessibility. Many of the interviewees mentioned how easy the app is to use and to find what you're looking for. Not just that, but the overall variety of entertainment provided, including music, podcasts, and e-books. "I use it every day and have access to all the music and podcasts I like" (participant 15). Spotify's value is tied to the habit of using it and how it integrates into their day-to-day life. Along with usage and the variety of options, many participants mentioned their appreciation for the algorithm built into Spotify. Participant 16 explained that she likes

when she is working, Spotify will continue to play songs, specifically the Ambient songs with no words that she prefers to hear. Having that personalized experience enhances a consumer's perceived value of a brand. Spotify having personal recommendations, playlists centered around what you listen to, and an algorithm that supports your personal choices creates tremendous value for the consumers. These features were mentioned by our participants who are loyal and will continue a long-term relationship with Spotify for the foreseeable future because of it. When it came to the price of a Spotify subscription, many of the interviewees had few complaints. A key insight we found was that most participants didn't care about the price. A few of them didn't even know how much they were paying for it and weren't concerned with the costs. One participant revealed she didn't know how much she paid because she and her husband had a duo plan. Participant 13 said, "If it ever costs more than \$25, I would take issue." Loyalty to Spotify is strong, but also dependent on various factors that could change at any time. As millennials, they have jobs that lead to financial stability. Therefore, many of them are not concerned with the cost of their subscription because of the value it brings to their daily life. Most of our interviewees discussed that they used Spotify daily. Whether it was on their way to work, while they were working, in the car going anywhere, listening to podcasts or e-books, playing music for their kids, Spotify is a crucial aspect of their lives. Which in turn means that the price is insignificant to them. In comparison to the competitors, we found a few key traits shared amongst the people we talked to. Many of them said they had never used other streaming services because they had been a Spotify member for so long and never felt the need to try other services. Participant 16 stated that "I used to use Apple Music, and think it has better sound quality than Spotify, but I like that Spotify's algorithm is more tailored to my wants." Many participants expressed the same appreciation for Spotify's personal consumer experience. They

thoroughly enjoyed that Spotify gave them recommendations, continued playing music based on their previously listened to songs, and the curated playlists provided to them by the AI-based algorithm. Along with this, the participants expressed that Spotify is extremely accessible to all forms of entertainment. A few of our interviewees have kids, and not only appreciate the “Family” subscription option, but also that there is kids' music and books available for them to use. Podcasts were a huge factor for many of our participants; they expressed that they listened to a variety of podcasts, but liked being able to have their music and podcasts in one location. On top of this, they also discussed that Spotify, in general, has a large selection of music, and you can listen to any type of music you want. While all participants were pleased with their subscription to Spotify, there were a few negative sentiments expressed. Some mentioned that ethically, they don't support Spotify because of its lack of payment to artists, specifically smaller ones. Overall, most participants would only change streaming services if the price became outrageously expensive compared to other platforms available or if Spotify as a company did something morally wrong.

Cognitive Map:



Summary of Findings: The findings from this qualitative research reveal that Millennials evaluate Spotify primarily through perceived value rather than price. This generation of people believes that Spotify is worth the cost, especially since it has personalized features that are important to their lifestyle. This means that Spotify has become a habitual part of their lifestyle as well. This has created a certain loyalty, not just towards music, but towards Spotify as well. The price doesn't concern our participants; in fact, many of them don't even know exactly what they pay. They care about the features, accessibility to the entertainment they want, and the continued ease of use through the AI-centered algorithm. However, our research also indicated that millennial loyalty is conditional. This is to say that although they may be loyal to Spotify based on their satisfaction with the service and their habitual use of it, they would still opt to use a different service if they perceived that the different service was offering greater value. This is significant in that it suggests that Spotify must continually strive to deliver a high level of innovation in terms of its user experience in order to retain this loyal millennial demographic.

Appendix

Participants:

Participant 1: Savannah Lloyd, 32, Female, (504)-296-2525, savannahgrace93@gmail.com

Participant 2: Addison Hinson, 30, Male, (504)-444-1430, addison.j.hinson@gmail.com

Participant 3: Barry Acosta, 34, Male, (504)-957-6942, barry.j.acosta@gmail.com

Participant 4: Ellie Klebe, 32, Female, (720)-799-3684, emklebe@gmail.com

Participant 5: Lauren Holley, 40, Female, (512-826-4748), laurenholley@didrillco.com

Participant 6: Cooper Delgado, 37, Male, (972-983-2926), cooperdelgado@gmail.com

Participant 7: Megan Cook, 40, Female, (214-544-5954), megancook@didrillco.com

Participant 8: Challen Demartino, 35, Female, (518-269-1755), ce12bana@alum.siena.edu

Participant 9: Barbra Davis, 32, Female, (508-965-4762), barbra.davis@siigroup.com

Participant 10: Gwen Rosendale, 36, Female, (580-747-5012), gwenn.iyer@gmail.com

Participant 11: Jessica Forte, 39, Female, (518-894-1780), jessforte5@gmail.com

Participant 12: Liz Arnold, 35, Female, (972-816-1192), lizarnold@yahoo.com

Participant 13: Kathleen Ashby, 40, Female, (385) 900-3406, Kathleen.ashby@gmail.com

Participant 14: Danielle Rosendale, 36, Female, (580) 548-3959, email

Participant 15: Lukas K, 40, Male, (385) 900-3039, Lukaskohoutek87@gmail.com

Participant 16: Kim Brown, 39, Female, (806) 316-8879, kimgriffith12@gmail.com

Questions:

1. How often do you listen to music on Spotify, and how does music fit into your daily life?
2. What factors influenced your decision to choose Spotify over other music streaming platforms?

3. How do you feel about Spotify's subscription price, and do you believe the value you receive justifies the cost?
4. How does Spotify compare to other music streaming platforms you've used or considered, particularly in terms of price and overall value? (Competitor)
5. What factors would make you consider switching from Spotify to a different music streaming service?
6. What aspects of Spotify make it worth continuing to pay for?
7. If you could change or improve anything about Spotify today, what would it be?

Consent Forms:



CONSENT TO PARTICIPATE IN RESEARCH

Study of Your Experience with Spotify

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Signature:  Date: 3/18



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Signature:  Date: 03/21/20



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Worth, Texas

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Signature: Cooper Delgado

Date: 3/19/2026



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Signature: Liz Arnold

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Signature: Lauren Holley

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Signature: 
Date: 3/15



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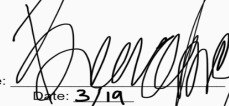
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